Kaimur hills on the eastern edge of the Vindhyas, the most direct route would have been along the valley of the Son river. The presence of Deo Markandeya, a site flourishing in Mauryan times and even before, shows that there would have been relatively little problem for ancient travellers who followed this alignment.[15] The other alignment from Pataliputra followed the Bodh-Gaya and Gaya line in order to gain access to the Kaimur hills, but there again two routes existed between Rajagriha and Gaya: one via the Barabar caves and another via Kurkihar.[16] Practically all these were ancient places of habitation and repute, and therefore it is impossible to decide which of these old historic alignments Ashoka will have chosen to follow. We can only be pretty certain he travelled on one of them.

He will have passed through captivating country. Anyone with even holidaying knowledge of the Central Indian hilly climes and the Malwa plateau will vouch for the beauty of the land. Masses of jungle terrain and incredible cliffs teeming with rock shelters are interspersed with long vistas of impressive undulating plateau areas and riverine plains. The Rewa jungles were in the nineteenth century often dense, full of trees like sal, tendu, saj, and khair, and were teeming with wildlife—tigers, leopards, bear, antelope, and chinkara deer.[17] Large parts of this territory must have been sparsely inhabited, but even so, some settlements and sites would have been found along the way. So, from Rewa towards the Jabalpur area the Magadhan entourage may well have chanced upon Rupnath and Kakrehta. Considering that at Rupnath there are springs full of water issuing from the rocks, the entourage may even have camped there and, if so, it may be one of the reasons why, many years later, Ashoka had a set of his royal edicts inscribed at this spot. But Kakrehta, only a kilometre from Rupnath, could also have been a stopover. Situated near the Suhar rivulet, a tributary of the Hiran river, historic pottery (North Black Polished Ware, among other types) of the Mauryan era was excavated out of its ancient mound, whose